

Overdrawing on Experience: Panpsychism and the Limits of First-Person Warrant

Abstract

Panpsychism often draws its force from an epistemic asymmetry. Physical science seems to describe matter in structural, relational, dispositional, or dynamic terms, while consciousness is known directly from the first-person point of view. This paper argues that the appeal is genuine but limited. The issue is not whether first-person experience alone proves panpsychism, but whether first-person warrant can transfer to the hidden posits panpsychism introduces. First-person experience establishes consciousness as a datum and shows that the experiences with which we are acquainted have phenomenal character. It does not, by itself, disclose bare metaphysical subjectivity, micro-experience, proto-experience, cosmic subjectivity, hidden phenomenal fields, or relations of phenomenal inheritance. Those posits may still be defended, but as theoretical posits, on the basis of the explanatory work they do. This also places the argument in debates over introspection and the revelation thesis: first-person acquaintance supports the datum of consciousness, not a hidden phenomenal ontology. Rather than derive consciousness from organization, the paper asks what explanatory work remains for a hidden phenomenal base once organization explains the structure of ordinary consciousness. The conclusion is not that panpsychism is false, but that it forfeits the special authority of first-person evidence when it moves beyond ordinary consciousness into hidden phenomenal ontology.

Keywords: panpsychism; first-person warrant; introspection; revelation thesis; Russellian monism; knowledge of consciousness; phenomenal consciousness; panprotopsychism; cosmopsychism; explanatory gap

1 Introduction: Panpsychism's Appeal

Panpsychism derives much of its contemporary appeal from an epistemic asymmetry. Consciousness, unlike many entities posited by physical science, is known from the first-person point of view. When I am in pain, I do not posit the pain as I posit an electron or a gene. The pain is given. Physical science, by contrast, is often taken to describe matter in structural, relational, and dispositional terms. It tells us what matter does, but not, at least on one influential line of thought, what matter is intrinsically. If consciousness is the one reality known from the inside, then perhaps consciousness, or something consciousness-like, belongs in our account of fundamental

reality. This thought gives panpsychism its distinctive force. It promises to avoid the apparent emergence of consciousness from an entirely non-conscious base by locating mentality, proto-mentality, or phenomenal character in the nature of matter itself. In its more sophisticated forms, the view is not the simple claim that electrons have recognizably human-like minds. Strawson’s realistic monism, for example, argues that a serious physicalism must take experience as part of the physical world and cannot treat experiential reality as an inexplicable late arrival (Strawson 2006). Goff’s Russellian monist defense places panpsychism in a broader argument about the categorical nature of matter and the limits of structural physics (Goff 2017a). The field also divides between micropsychist views, which begin from many small subjects and try to combine them into ordinary minds, and cosmopsychist views, which begin from a single cosmic subject and try to derive local minds from it; both forms figure in what follows.

The appeal to first-person experience also imposes a constraint. If first-person experience is the source of panpsychism’s special warrant, then the view may claim that warrant only for what first-person experience actually discloses. Three questions need to be kept apart here: whether conscious experience exists, what features it has, and what its metaphysical status is. First-person experience answers the first robustly. It bears on the second more cautiously, since our grasp of phenomenal character may be partial and fallible. It does not by itself answer the third, which asks whether consciousness is fundamental, intrinsic, derivative, organizational, microphysical, or cosmic. First-person experience is indispensable evidence for consciousness, but it does not settle consciousness’s metaphysical status.

That authority is easy to overextend. The datum supplied by experience is real but finite. It establishes that consciousness exists and discloses features of ordinary conscious life. It does not establish that consciousness is fundamental, ubiquitous, microphysical, cosmic, or hidden in the categorical basis of physical structure. I focus on that transfer of warrant, while broader defenses of panpsychism and nonstructural explanations of consciousness remain available as theoretical options. Even pure-awareness cases, sometimes treated as the clearest first-person evidence, depend, when used as public evidence, on reports, memory, temporal location, and a standpoint from which the episode can later be described.

Panpsychism may still be true. One of its most powerful motivations, however, becomes less direct than it first appears. If the hidden phenomenal base is not itself disclosed in experience, panpsychism has not dissolved the emergence problem in advance. The gap reappears between that hidden base and the consciousness we actually undergo. Goff’s recent treatment of subjects as strongly emergent makes this reappearance visible from within his own framework (Goff 2024).

2 Scope and Bracketing

The scope is limited. Panpsychists may appeal to the alleged impossibility of radical emergence, to continuity in nature, to theoretical simplicity, to dissatisfaction with standard physicalism, or to the explanatory gap. They may also defend a Russellian

monist thesis according to which physics describes only structure and dynamics, leaving the intrinsic nature of matter unspecified. Those arguments raise large issues that cannot be settled here.

The bracketing is only a limit on the present argument. Alter develops a recent route from the knowledge argument to Russellian monism, and Pereboom treats Russellian monism as part of the prospects for physicalism (Alter 2023; Pereboom 2011). Stoljar's ignorance-based treatment of the consciousness problem is also relevant, since it warns against moving too quickly from epistemic limitation to metaphysical conclusion (Stoljar 2006). These are serious options, and I will not try to settle them here.

My target is narrower. I am concerned with one prominent motivation for panpsychism: the claim that consciousness has a special epistemic status because it is known directly from within. This motivation matters because it gives panpsychism a distinctive rhetorical and philosophical force. The panpsychist appears to begin from the one thing we know most intimately, namely experience itself.

The argument is not aimed at panpsychism as such. It is aimed at a specific transfer of warrant: the move from the authority of ordinary first-person consciousness to the hidden phenomenal posits that panpsychism introduces.

That route is legitimate as far as it goes. Its reach is limited. First-person experience may establish the reality of consciousness. It may also disclose features of conscious life that any adequate theory should respect. It does not automatically support claims about the distribution, fundamentality, or cosmic structure of consciousness.

This scope restriction is important because a panpsychist could otherwise object that the paper confuses two questions. One question is whether consciousness exists and is known in a distinctive first-person way. A second question is whether consciousness, or something related to it, belongs to the fundamental nature of matter. The first question can be answered from the first-person point of view. The second cannot. It requires a metaphysical argument.

I bracket the full case for Russellian monism, but I take up one step within it: the move from the claim that physics gives only structure and dynamics to the claim that the categorical basis of structure is phenomenal. Even if physics gives only structure and dynamics, it does not follow that the categorical nature behind that structure is phenomenal or proto-phenomenal. The structure/dynamics argument may create a vacancy. It does not show that consciousness fills it.

A panpsychist may reply that no careful defender claims first-person experience alone proves panpsychism. That reply is right. The stronger argument is abductive: consciousness is known directly; physics gives only structure; radical emergence looks suspect; panpsychism is offered as the best metaphysical hypothesis. The remaining problem concerns the weight assigned to the first-person datum. Even when the inference is framed abductively, that datum can still be made to carry more weight than the abduction earns.

The contrast with physicalism shows the pressure. Panpsychism often presents itself as the view that takes consciousness with full seriousness, while physicalism is said either to deny the datum or to disguise its derivation. That contrast depends on

the thought that panpsychism uniquely preserves the standing of first-person experience. Once the argument is abductive, however, the warrant has changed kind. Panpsychism becomes a theoretical proposal, like its rivals. Its hidden phenomenal ontology now has to explain enough to justify its cost.

The cost is clearest at the point where panpsychism seemed to relieve the pressure of emergence. Placing phenomenality at the fundamental level makes the relation between ordinary consciousness and its substrate look easier than it is for physicalism. That appearance depends on treating the first-person datum as already bearing on the fundamental level. Once the question is theoretical, that relief from emergence is no longer secured in advance. The abduction may begin from the first-person datum, but it cannot retain the datum's special authority for the hidden ontology it introduces. It treats experience as the right kind of item to fill the gap that physics leaves, and that fittingness claim is itself metaphysical. The structure-and-dynamics argument may leave a categorical role open. Experience may be proposed as the occupant of that role. But neither step is delivered by acquaintance with one's own consciousness. What we know from within is organized, temporal experience with phenomenal character, anchored in a body and a history. Whether that experience reveals intrinsic, categorical, or fundamental nature is precisely what needs argument. With that distinction in place, panpsychism may remain a legitimate metaphysical theory while forfeiting the special authority of first-person evidence.

The worry reaches careful formulations as well as careless ones. Strawson explicitly treats experience as "the fundamental given natural fact" and as an obligatory starting point for any realistic theory of what exists (Strawson 2006, 4). Goff's case against physicalism includes a Revelation thesis, roughly, that the nature of our conscious states is introspectively revealed to us (Goff 2017a, 106–132). These are careful philosophers, and neither should be read as making a crude inference from pain to conscious electrons. Still, their arguments gain force from the thought that experience enjoys an epistemic standing unlike that of ordinary theoretical posits. The issue is how far that standing can legitimately travel.

The discussion belongs near the recent literature on the combination problem and constitutive panpsychism, much of which is organized around the terrain mapped in Brüntrup and Jaskolla (2017). Chalmers distinguishes panpsychism from panprotopsyism and formulates the combination problem as a central obstacle for views that derive macro-consciousness from micro-level phenomenal or proto-phenomenal facts (Chalmers 2015, 2017). Coleman presses the subject-summing problem against micropsychist combination (Coleman 2014). Mørch argues that dispositionalism about properties supports a phenomenal-powers panpsychism, and develops the broader phenomenal-powers metaphysics elsewhere, while Roelofs defends the coherence of composite subjectivity against several anti-combination arguments (Mørch 2020, forthcoming; Roelofs 2019). Those debates ask whether panpsychism can make good on its internal explanatory obligations. My question is prior in the order of warrant: when these views introduce micro-experience, proto-phenomenal powers, phenomenal bonding, composite subjects, or cosmic subjectivity, what part of their support comes from first-person evidence, and what part must be earned as theory?

Nagel's classic discussion asks whether panpsychism follows from claims about mental properties, reduction, and material composition (Nagel 1979). The issue here is narrower. First-person experience may warrant the reality of consciousness while leaving open whether panpsychism's hidden phenomenal ontology has any direct warrant from that datum.

Two recent papers make this adjacency especially close. Lin argues that revelation cannot favor panpsychism over physicalism, since Chalmers's distinction between the essence of phenomenal properties and their grounds either fails to rescue panpsychism or can be used by physicalists as well (Lin 2025). Roelofs argues that constitutive panpsychists can accept a medium-strength revelation thesis without being committed to every constitutive fact about consciousness appearing transparently in introspection (Roelofs 2020). Together, those papers clarify what is at stake in revelation, while leaving a further warrant issue in view: even if first-person acquaintance establishes consciousness as a datum, how far can that warrant travel when panpsychism introduces hidden phenomenal ontology?

There is also at least one explicit first-person route to panpsychism. Ramm defends panpsychist idealism by beginning from the first-person perspective and using phenomenological reflection to motivate a broader idealist-panpsychist picture (Ramm 2021). That argument gives the worry a named target: first-person evidence is being asked to do metaphysical work. My objection is that such work must be carefully limited. First-person reflection may disclose ordinary experience, but it does not by itself disclose the hidden phenomenal structure of the world.

Several familiar pressures converge here. The reportability point is close to Lin's treatment of selfless states and Windt's work on dreamless sleep. The depsychologization worry overlaps with Frankish. The combination problem as theoretical burden runs through Chalmers and Coleman. The structure/dynamics rejoinder follows a familiar physicalist response. Read together, these pressures ask one warrant question: when panpsychism moves from ordinary experience to hidden phenomenal ontology, what is still supported by first-person evidence, and what has become theory? The contribution is to show what panpsychism forfeits when the first-person route is treated as abduction, and to make explicit the further assumption that experience is the right kind of item to fill the categorical role that structural physics is said to leave open.

3 The Introspective Warrant Constraint

Panpsychism often draws force from a claim about the special epistemic status of consciousness. Consciousness is not known in the way electrons, genes, or black holes are known. I do not posit my current pain as a theoretical entity. I undergo it. Conscious experience is given from the first-person point of view.

This appeal is legitimate, but it must be disciplined. Direct knowledge of consciousness gives warrant for what is actually given in experience. It does not give every entity described as phenomenal, proto-phenomenal, or experiential the same standing. The warrant attaches to what is given, not to whatever a theory chooses to describe in similar terms.

First-person acquaintance gives immediate warrant for the occurrence and character of the experience one is acquainted with. It does not, by itself, warrant claims about the distribution, fundamentality, categorical role, or cosmic or microphysical basis of consciousness. That is the introspective warrant constraint:

A theory that motivates itself by appeal to first-person experience may claim first-person warrant only for what first-person experience actually discloses.

The constraint guards against treating the direct warrant of ordinary consciousness as if it directly supported hidden phenomenal ontology. It is modest. It allows theoretical posits. Physics, biology, and psychology all legitimately posit entities and structures not given in ordinary experience. But those posits are warranted by explanatory, predictive, or unificatory work. They do not inherit the authority of first-person acquaintance. If panpsychism posits micro-experience, proto-experience, cosmic subjectivity, hidden phenomenal fields, or relations of phenomenal inheritance, those posits may be defended as theoretical entities. They may not be treated as if they were directly warranted by the first-person datum of consciousness.

The datum is modest: consciousness exists. There is something it is like to undergo pain, see red, hear a sound, remember a face, or feel time passing. The characterization of the datum is also modest: the experiences with which we are acquainted have phenomenal character. This claim does not require that phenomenal character be sharp, stable, or fully articulable. A mood may be vague, peripheral vision indeterminate, and anticipation foggy. These are still ways experience is given. Vagueness and foggy are themselves phenomenal characters, not routes to a subjectivity without any phenomenal character at all. The characterization is therefore compatible with hard cases, including minimal experience, meditative states, moods, objectless anxiety, reports of dreamless sleep, and claims about pure consciousness. Those cases can be granted. Acquaintance still does not present consciousness as bare metaphysical subjectivity without any phenomenal character at all. Metaphysical inflation begins when consciousness, proto-consciousness, or subjectivity is said to belong to the fundamental nature of matter, to exist at the microphysical level, or to characterize the universe as a whole.

The introspective warrant constraint allows the first step. It also allows the second. But it blocks any automatic passage to the third. First-person experience warrants the existence of ordinary consciousness and discloses something about its character. It does not by itself disclose consciousness as belonging to the fundamental level as such, to the microphysical level in particular, or to the categorical basis of physical reality.

This constraint matters because panpsychism often presents itself as unusually faithful to consciousness. Its promise is to take experience seriously rather than explaining it away. But taking experience seriously also means taking seriously the limits of what experience gives. First-person experience gives us conscious life with some determinate phenomenal character. It does not give us bare subjectivity detached from all character, nor micro-experiences hidden in particles, nor proto-experiential categorical properties, nor a unified cosmic experienter.

4 What First-Person Experience Discloses

The first-person datum is sometimes described as bare subjectivity, pure awareness, or mere what-it-is-likeness. That description is tempting because it seems to isolate the minimal feature common to all conscious states. Yet it risks abstracting away precisely the features that make consciousness intelligible as a datum.

When we attend to consciousness, we do not find subjectivity as an empty item standing apart from all character. In ordinary waking cases, we find sensation, mood, thought, temporal flow, embodiment, and varying degrees of attention. Less ordinary cases should be treated with care. A meditative state, an objectless mood, or a claimed pure-consciousness state may lack many features of ordinary experience. But insofar as it is available to first-person acquaintance, it is available as something: calm, blank, diffuse, silent, contentless, expansive, or otherwise phenomenally determinate. The relevant point is not that every conscious state represents an external object. It is that the experiences we can appeal to as evidence are never given as bare metaphysical subjectivity.

Appeals to fundamental subjectivity now face a question. Does the posited fundamental consciousness have phenomenal character, or not? If it does, then it already has structure that calls for explanation, and cannot be the simple primitive known by introspection alone. If it does not, then it is not something first-person experience discloses at all, but an abstraction from experience rather than an item found in it.

The dilemma is especially important for views that retreat from rich consciousness to minimal subjectivity. The move is understandable. Few panpsychists want to say that electrons have visual fields, memories, anxieties, or personal identities. So the relevant posit is often thinned out. The fundamental level is said to contain minimal phenomenal character, bare subjectivity, or proto-experiential nature. But thinning the posit changes its epistemic status. The thinner it becomes, the less it resembles the consciousness that first-person experience actually gives. Thinning also does not escape the first horn of the dilemma. Whatever phenomenal character is retained, however minimal, is character of some determinate sort; structure does not vanish by being made small. A posit with minimal phenomenal character still has phenomenal character, and that character still demands the kind of explanation the dilemma required.

A natural reply is that panpsychism is doing what scientific theorizing often does: abstracting a property from familiar cases and assigning it to entities in which it does not appear in familiar form. We abstract mass from heavy bodies and assign it to particles we cannot feel. Why not abstract phenomenality from ordinary experience and assign it to the fundamental level?

The analogy is useful, but limited. Mass is embedded in a network of measurement and intervention that supplies warrant for applying it beyond the cases in which we first encounter it. We know what it would be for an unfamiliar entity to have mass, because mass has behavioral signatures that can be tracked without acquaintance. Its identity is fixed by its role in theory and practice, not by the felt heaviness of familiar objects. Phenomenality is different. We do not encounter it apart from there being some way the experience is given. If phenomenality is stripped of temporality, perspective, valence, and every determinate mode of givenness, it is no longer clear

what property has been isolated. The panpsychist may still posit such a thin property, but the posit is now theoretical. It no longer carries the first-person authority of the experience from which the abstraction began.

A related reply says that minimal phenomenal character can be primitive at the fundamental level, in the sense that it is not further analyzable into more basic phenomenal constituents, while still being determinate. The first horn of the dilemma is then conceded, but its consequence is denied: determinate character need not call for reductive explanation if no further phenomenal analysis is available. The reply concedes more than it gains. Even an unanalyzable determinate phenomenal character is still some way rather than another, and the question why it has the form it has remains a question, even when no further phenomenal decomposition can answer it. Granting the primitive's coherence also does not yet pay the debt that matters most to the panpsychist: the route from a primitive micro-character to the determinate macro-consciousness we have is still owed. The dilemma's purpose was not to require reductive analysis of phenomenality but to show that bare characterless subjectivity cannot be the datum, and that any determinate alternative inherits explanatory burdens the panpsychist's first-person motivation was supposed to forestall.

Minimal subjectivity may be coherent. It still cannot simply borrow the warrant of ordinary experience. The familiar datum is structured consciousness. A stripped-down subjectivity with no content, valence, temporality, or structure is not given in the same way. If it is introduced, it is introduced by theory.

This point overlaps with Frankish's worry about the depsychologization of consciousness in panpsychist contexts (Frankish 2021). The more consciousness is stripped of the psychological roles by which we ordinarily recognize it, the less clear it becomes that the retained posit is still the consciousness from which the argument began. I do not rely on an illusionist conclusion. The more modest point is enough: a depsychologized or contentless posit may be a coherent theoretical posit. It is not simply the first-person datum under another name.

One point about ordinary phenomenology is worth emphasizing before the harder cases. Even at the most attenuated end of waking consciousness, what is given is not nothing. There is some sense of presence, of for-me-ness, of the moment's being a moment for the one undergoing it. That sense is itself a phenomenal character, however thin, and not a structureless occupant of consciousness. That claim is phenomenological, not evidential. It concerns what acquaintance presents, not what a later report or memory can reconstruct.

4.1 The Reportability Constraint

The strongest challenge here comes from meditators who report pure or contentless awareness. They describe moments of consciousness without any object, self, or thought, which is exactly the kind of bare subjectivity the previous section denied was given in experience. Metzinger develops minimal phenomenal experience as a candidate for the simplest form of consciousness, drawing on meditative reports of pure awareness and tonic alertness (Metzinger 2020). Gamma and Metzinger's questionnaire study extends this project empirically by using reports from meditators to profile

minimal phenomenal experience (Gamma and Metzinger 2021). Philosophical treatments of witness-consciousness and pure awareness likewise suggest that awareness may be present without ordinary object-directed content, self-identification, or discursive thought (Albahari 2006, 2009; Thompson 2014). Meditation-induced cessations raise a related but distinct issue. They are often described as interruptions, absences, or border cases of consciousness. Still, they make the evidential problem especially vivid: what reaches the philosophical discussion is always a report of an episode in which ordinary consciousness was said to be absent (Laukkonen et al. 2023).

These cases should be granted for the sake of argument. I need not deny that there are minimal, nondual, selfless, or apparently contentless states. Nor do I need to decide whether *nirodha samapatti* is best described as consciousness without content, absence of consciousness, or a remembered transition around an absence. When such states function as public philosophical evidence, they reach the theorist through report, memory, interpretation, and later classification. The constraint that follows concerns that public use, not the private episodes themselves. The argument is not that a phenomenal episode must have had structure because its later report does; whatever character the episode had, the question is what argumentative weight a later report can carry without independent access to it. A panpsychist might say that private acquaintance with pure awareness need not be report-mediated. But then the original dilemma returns: either the state is privately given with some phenomenal character, however attenuated, or it is not disclosed as experience in the relevant first-person sense.

A reportable episode must be available later as something that occurred. It must be retained or reconstructed in memory and attributed in some way to the subject who reports it. Lin makes the point sharper for selfless states. If a state is supposed to be wholly selfless, it is hard to see how an autobiographical memory of it can establish what it was like (Lin 2022).

The same form of pressure applies to contentless-awareness reports when they are taken to establish the absence of phenomenal structure. Zahavi argues that experiential subjectivity cannot be cleanly detached from a minimal *for-me-ness* or from a bodily perspective, and Henry and Thompson press a similar point in direct engagement with Albahari (Zahavi 2005; Henry and Thompson 2011).

There is also a temporal version of the problem. A reportable episode must be located at least minimally in a before-and-after order. Windt makes this point for dreamless sleep by arguing that even putatively content-poor sleep experience involves a minimal temporality, such as duration or the sense of having been (Windt 2015). That temporal structure may be very thin. If temporal structure is present, the report bears witness to more than bare subjectivity. If temporal structure is absent, the retrospective report cannot establish the state as a first-person datum with no temporal structure.

Contentless-awareness reports still have evidential value. At most, though, they support the possibility of attenuated phenomenal character, reduced object-directedness, weakened self-representation, or unusual temporal and bodily structure. They do not establish bare metaphysical subjectivity as a datum. Indeed, the more a report says was absent during the episode (memory, selfhood, temporal grain), the

more cautiously it must be used as first-person evidence. The ordinary conditions for accurate retrospective report are exactly what the report says were suspended. Schwitzgebel's general worries about introspective unreliability therefore compound the present restriction rather than replacing it (Schwitzgebel 2008, 2011).

The central dilemma remains. If pure awareness has some phenomenal character, even an attenuated character such as silence, openness, or bare temporality, then it is not characterless subjectivity. If it has no phenomenal character at all, then it is not disclosed as experience in the way ordinary first-person evidence discloses pain or temporal flow. Either way, the appeal to pure awareness does not license the transfer from first-person acquaintance to a hidden ontology of bare fundamental consciousness. That conclusion was already in view from ordinary phenomenology and from the dilemma about characterless subjectivity; the strongest first-person challenge does not unsettle it.

5 The Failure of Warrant Transfer

The introspective warrant constraint becomes most important when panpsychism moves from ordinary consciousness to hidden phenomenal ontology. Contemporary panpsychist and panprotopsychist views may posit micro-experience, proto-experience, proto-phenomenal properties, cosmic subjectivity, hidden phenomenal fields, phenomenal bonding relations, or forms of phenomenal inheritance. These posits are not directly disclosed in ordinary first-person experience.

Such posits may be possible. They still cannot automatically inherit the epistemic privilege of first-person consciousness. The immediacy of pain warrants the pain, not a cosmic subject behind it; and the directness of visual experience warrants only that visual experience occurs, not that the microphysical entities involved in vision instantiate hidden phenomenal natures.

Revelation deserves direct attention here, since it is the strongest principle by which acquaintance might be thought to reach beyond ordinary experience. The thesis says, in broad form, that acquaintance with an experience reveals its nature. Goff defends a strong version on which introspection delivers the essence of phenomenal states; Roelofs defends a more moderate version on which it delivers less than the full constitutive story (Goff 2017a; Roelofs 2020). The constraint runs even on the moderate version. What revelation can disclose, on any plausible formulation, is what is given in acquaintance, and what is given is given at the grain of ordinary experience, in features like sensation, color, pain, mood, and for-me-ness. Revelation may deepen our grasp of those features without delivering the hidden architecture panpsychism builds on top. The constraint does not require revelation to fail; it requires only that what revelation reveals does not by itself include what panpsychism then introduces.

The warrant issue intersects the combination literature. Panpsychism's biggest internal puzzle is the combination problem: how do many small minds add up to one large mind? It is often treated as the question of how micro-experiences, micro-subjects, or proto-phenomenal bases could yield the macro-consciousness we know from our own case (Chalmers 2017; Coleman 2014; Roelofs 2019). But the very formulation already contains posits not delivered by the first-person datum: micro-subjects,

micro-experiences, bonding relations, structural correspondences between micro- and macro-experience, or powers whose phenomenal nature grounds physical dispositions. If those posits solve the combination problem, they may be justified by that success. Such justification would be theoretical. It would not be the direct authority of first-person acquaintance carried downward or outward.

Mørch's phenomenal powers view is a particularly useful test case. On that view, phenomenal properties are not idle qualia but powers that can ground physical dispositions (Mørch 2020, forthcoming). If successful, this would give panpsychism a substantive explanatory role. But it also makes the present constraint sharper. First-person experience may acquaint us with phenomenal character, and perhaps with agency, motivation, or felt efficacy in ordinary cases. It does not follow that we are acquainted with fundamental phenomenal powers that ground the dispositional structure described by physics. That further claim needs theoretical support beyond the authority of acquaintance.

Panprotopsychism makes the warrant-transfer problem especially clear. The panprotopsychist need not say that fundamental entities are conscious. The claim is that they instantiate proto-phenomenal or proto-experiential properties that can help explain consciousness. But proto-experience is not something we encounter from within. It is introduced as a theoretical posit. Introspection is, by what it does, acquaintance with experience; its reach is whatever reach experience has. So calling something proto-experiential in the same breath as ordinary experience does not by itself extend acquaintance to it. Its relation to ordinary consciousness must therefore be argued for, not assumed.

Here the panprotopsychist faces a dilemma. If proto-experience is sufficiently like experience, then it inherits familiar problems about structure, unity, subjecthood, and combination. If it is sufficiently unlike experience, then it loses its claim to first-person warrant. Either way, the appeal to ordinary consciousness does less work than advertised.

Phenomenal bonding faces the same limit. Goff's discussion of phenomenal bonding is explicitly designed to address the combination problem, the problem of how many micro-level subjects or phenomenal properties could yield one macro-level subject (Goff 2017b). That machinery may be part of a serious metaphysical theory. But it is not given in ordinary first-person experience. I am acquainted with pain, color, thought, and temporal flow. I am not acquainted, simply by being conscious, with relations by which micro-subjects combine into macro-subjects.

Panpsychism overdraws on first-person evidence when it treats the epistemic privilege of ordinary consciousness as support for a hidden phenomenal ontology. Once it moves beyond what is actually given in first-person experience, it loses the special authority of that evidence. At that point, panpsychism is doing what functionalists, materialists, emergentists, and other theorists do: observing the world, interpreting evidence, and making theoretical inferences. Its hidden phenomenal posits may still be legitimate, but they no longer carry the distinctive authority of direct acquaintance.

6 Structure and Dynamics Do Not Rescue the Inference

The Russellian monist can press a further argument. Physics, it is said, gives us only structure and dynamics. It describes relations, dispositions, equations, and causal roles. It leaves open the intrinsic or categorical nature of the entities that bear those roles. Consciousness, by contrast, is known from within. Perhaps consciousness reveals what matter is intrinsically, or at least gives us a model for what intrinsic nature could be (Goff 2017a; Alter 2023; Pereboom 2011).

The argument begins from a real limitation in structural description rather than a simple appeal to mystery. If a theory tells us only how entities are related or how they behave, one may ask what, if anything, has the structure or grounds the dispositions. Alter's recent defense of Russellian monism makes the vacancy more than a rhetorical device: the claim is that standard physical description omits intrinsic properties that may both underlie physical structure and bear on consciousness (Alter 2023). Pereboom's discussion matters for a different reason. It shows that Russellian monism need not be introduced as a straightforward rejection of physicalism, but can be explored as part of a physicalist response to arguments from consciousness (Pereboom 2011). These uses differ, but they share the thought that physical description may leave an intrinsic-nature question open.

It is also clear why the panpsychist finds phenomenal filling tempting. If physics leaves categorical nature unspecified, and if consciousness is the one concrete reality whose nature seems available from the inside, then consciousness appears to be the only available model of intrinsic nature. The move is not arbitrary. It is an attempt to use the one apparent case of acquaintance to illuminate what structural physics leaves dark.

But the step from vacancy to phenomenal filling is not licensed by first-person experience alone. From the claim that matter has an unknown intrinsic nature, it does not follow that this intrinsic nature is experiential or proto-experiential. Inferring the intrinsic nature of the fundamental from a salient macro-level feature requires an independent reason to think that the feature is suited to play that role. First-person experience discloses ordinary consciousness. It does not disclose the intrinsic nature of electrons, fields, spacetime, or the cosmos. Nor does it disclose ordinary consciousness as fundamental categorical nature. Consciousness may be intrinsic, derivative, emergent, organizational, or something else. Acquaintance with experience does not settle which metaphysical reading is correct. To identify categorical physical nature with phenomenal or proto-phenomenal nature is therefore a metaphysical inference.

Russellian monism survives this point. A Russellian panpsychist may have further arguments. The claim may be defended by appeal to simplicity, explanatory gap considerations, anti-emergentist premises, or a broader theory of categorical properties. But once the argument takes that form, it no longer rests on first-person immediacy. It rests on a theory about what best fills an explanatory or metaphysical gap.

First-person evidence has unusual authority only within its proper domain. I can be directly aware of my pain. I cannot be directly aware, by that same act, that the intrinsic nature of all matter is pain-like, experience-like, or proto-phenomenal.

The structure/dynamics argument may explain why a panpsychist looks for something beyond structural physics. It does not show that the thing found must be consciousness. At most, consciousness supplies a candidate model for intrinsic nature. The suitability of that model must be defended by the theory, since first-person acquaintance supplies the experience itself rather than its fundamental metaphysical role.

7 Goff, Strawson, and Degrees of Strain

The introspective warrant problem applies with different force to different panpsychist views: austere realistic monism, micropsychism, cosmopsychism, panprotopsychism, and phenomenal-powers grounding each face it differently. Some views lean directly on first-person evidence for the posits they introduce. Some are already operating as abductive metaphysical theories while still drawing dialectical force from first-person privilege. Some make no first-person warrant claim at all, in which case the constraint does not apply to them. A fair criticism should not treat every version of panpsychism as if it made the same claim.

Strawson’s realistic monism is the austere baseline. He argues that experience is real, that experience is physical if physicalism is true, and that the emergence of experience from the wholly non-experiential would be unintelligible (Strawson 2006). His text leaves the move on the surface. Experience is “the fundamental given natural fact” (Strawson 2006, 4), and treating it as given in this strong sense is what licenses the argument to move directly from acquaintance to constraints on what fundamental theory may then look like. That licensing step is the one the paper is questioning. This argument does not depend on recognizably human-like particle minds. It is a serious attempt to force physicalism to include experience within the physical.

Strawson may be right that experience is part of reality and cannot be dismissed. First-person acquaintance with ordinary experience still does not warrant the stronger claim that experientiality exists at the fundamental level. The introspective warrant constraint permits the datum of experience. It does not permit an automatic inference from that datum to microphysical experientiality.

Goff’s more elaborate Russellian and cosmopsychist machinery makes the problem sharper. His work develops panpsychism within a structure/dynamics framework and addresses the combination problem through proposals such as phenomenal bonding and cosmopsychism (Goff 2017a,b, 2019). Goff also defends a Revelation thesis on which introspective awareness of a phenomenal state amounts to acquaintance with its essential nature, and that thesis does serious argumentative work in his case against physicalism (Goff 2017a, 106–132). The strong claim about essence is what the paper questions, not the weaker claim that acquaintance reveals something about experience. Whatever acquaintance reveals about the character of an experience, it does not by itself reveal the metaphysical role of that experience. Cosmopsychism is especially important because it reverses the micropsychist direction. Instead of beginning with many micro-subjects and trying to combine them into human subjects, it begins with a cosmic subject and attempts to derive local subjects from it.

This may avoid some versions of the combination problem. But it worsens the introspective warrant problem. Cosmic subjectivity is hidden from third-person science and unlike anything first-person experience discloses. Ordinary first-person experience reveals local, finite, perspectival consciousness with determinate phenomenal character. It is also bounded and affectively grained: one is acquainted with one's own experiences and not with anyone else's, and what is given is given as mattering in some way, pleasant or aversive or neutral. Perspectival closure and affective valence both belong to the datum, and neither is delivered by a unified cosmic experiencer from which local minds derive.

That claim should not be read as assuming that cosmopsychism faces a simple mirror image of micropsychism's combination problem. Shani explicitly resists that framing and argues that cosmopsychic individuation need not be understood as the reverse of micropsychist subject-summing (Shani 2015, 2022). Albahari and Mørch likewise explore versions of cosmic or universal consciousness that complicate simple charges about decombination and unity (Albahari 2019; Mørch 2024). The present point is narrower. Even if these views offer a coherent theory of cosmic individuation, the cosmic subject is not disclosed in ordinary first-person acquaintance. Its warrant is therefore holistic, metaphysical, or explanatory, not directly first-personal.

Goff's more recent hybrid cosmopsychism also changes the target. He now treats subjects as strongly emergent while phenomenal properties are weakly emergent, in part to explain how panpsychism is supposed to help with consciousness without inheriting the worst forms of subject-combination difficulty (Goff 2024). This refinement concedes strong emergence at the level of subjects, which is precisely where much of the original anti-emergentist pressure was supposed to bite. Goff's view may still be defensible. The concession matters because the anti-emergentist appeal can no longer carry the full first-person motivation for panpsychism by itself. Once panpsychism explains ordinary subjecthood through emergence, grounding, and top-down structure, it is operating as a theoretical metaphysics. It cannot simply retain the immediacy of the original first-person datum for the full hidden ontology it introduces.

Other sophisticated responses differ in detail. Mørch's phenomenal powers view tries to make phenomenal properties do causal and grounding work, and Roelofs's composite-subject strategy tries to resist the inference from the apparent privacy of subjects to the impossibility of mental combination (Mørch 2020; Roelofs 2019). These are constructive theories, with machinery meant to do more than carry first-person consciousness down to the particle level. Roelofs in particular can say that constitutive panpsychism need not predict introspective access to micro-properties. The micro-properties constitute what is introspected, but they need not themselves appear as objects of introspection. That reply may protect the theory from a simple phenomenological objection, while sharpening the present point.

The constraint targets a pattern of warrant, not individual writers. When a panpsychist treats the inference as fully abductive, the constraint records that fact rather than objecting to it. Panpsychism often continues to draw its appeal, in introductions, summaries, and discussions of why the view is worth taking seriously, from the special standing of first-person consciousness. Once the micro-level is not introspectively disclosed, first-person evidence no longer warrants it directly.

A constitutive panpsychist may press the point in the other direction: if ordinary consciousness is literally constituted by micro-experiences, then introspecting it already amounts to indirect acquaintance with what makes it up. The reply is that constitution and acquaintance are different relations. Cells constitute me, but I am not acquainted with my cells by being acquainted with myself. Even granting the constitutive picture, introspection presents the integrated whole rather than the items that compose it, so the first-person datum does not reach the micro-level by passing through the macro. The same point can be put in terms of grain. Even if perceiving a painting involves perceiving its brushstrokes, the perceiver is acquainted with the painting at the painting's grain, not with brushstrokes as such. Acquaintance presents at some grain, and that grain is the grain at which warrant is given; a coarser-grain acquaintance does not by itself deliver finer-grain acquaintance with whatever constitutes it. What has been given up is the opening asymmetry: the claim that consciousness enjoys a special epistemic standing because it is known from within. The constitutive claim must then be defended by its theoretical role in explaining the macro-consciousness that is disclosed.

Appeals to phenomenal acquaintance face the same limit. Suppose, with the panpsychist, that acquaintance with experience gives us some unusually intimate grasp of the nature of experience. Even then, acquaintance reaches only the experience with which one is acquainted. It does not by itself acquaint us with micro-experiences, proto-phenomenal categorical bases, cosmic subjectivity, or the relations by which local subjects might derive from a wider subject. The appeal to acquaintance may therefore support claims about ordinary experience. It does not automatically extend to the hidden phenomenal architecture introduced to make panpsychism work.

The more panpsychism elaborates the machinery needed to solve its internal problems, the farther it moves from the first-person datum that gave it plausibility. The machinery may still be true. But once it is detached from the immediacy of acquaintance, it has to be defended on the same theoretical footing as any other metaphysical hypothesis. Sophisticated replies often accept this. They grant that the hidden posits are not given in first-person experience and defend them by theory instead. At that point panpsychism becomes an abductive metaphysical theory whose support must come from explanatory payoff rather than first-person authority.

8 Explanatory Burden

Treating panpsychist posits as theoretical rather than first-personal shifts the burden. Micro-experience, proto-experience, or cosmic subjectivity may be possible. The harder question is what these posits explain. Once first-person warrant is no longer available for them, the hidden phenomenal base must be justified by explanatory work.

This burden is not a penalty imposed on panpsychism alone. Any theory incurs it once its central posits are no longer directly given.

An adequate theory of consciousness should help explain its unity, its contents, its temporal grain, its sensitivity to factors such as sleep and anesthesia, the difference between processes that enter experience and those that do not, and why experience has valence. Panpsychism need not explain all of these features by its fundamental

phenomenal base alone. A panpsychist can reasonably say that attention, memory, reportability, temporal integration, and many contents depend on organization. That concession is important. It locates the pressure point more precisely.

Once organization is doing the work of explaining the structure of ordinary consciousness, the remaining question is what explanatory work belongs to the hidden phenomenal base. If its main role is to block brute emergence from the wholly non-phenomenal, that may be a serious metaphysical role. But it is not yet an explanation of the determinate structure of the consciousness we actually undergo. The panpsychist therefore owes an account of what the hidden base contributes, beyond occupying the place where brute emergence would otherwise appear. Otherwise the posit marks the need for explanation rather than supplying one. The pressure is sharpest at the combination problem. Micro-experiences were introduced as the right kind of thing to combine into ordinary consciousness. If organization does the combining work, the micro-experiences must still make a distinctive contribution in virtue of being experiential; otherwise the same organizational story could, in principle, be told over non-experiential materials.

This point supplies no complete emergentist theory of consciousness. I am not deriving phenomenality from organization, nor claiming to solve the hard problem. The question remains why any organized processing should feel like anything at all. Panpsychism relocates that difficulty into the relation between fundamental phenomenal or proto-phenomenal properties and the determinate consciousness we actually undergo. Unless those hidden properties explain enough to justify their theoretical cost, the abductive burden remains in place.

Papineau's treatment of the explanatory gap and phenomenal concepts presses a nearby concern. Papineau argues that the felt gap between physical and phenomenal description may arise from how we think about conscious states, not from the need to posit extra non-physical ontology (Papineau 2002). The broader phenomenal concept strategy develops this diagnosis in different ways: the epistemic asymmetry between phenomenal and physical thought may be explained by the character of phenomenal concepts rather than by a further phenomenal ingredient in reality (Loar 1990; Balog 2012; Carruthers and Veillet 2007). My claim is narrower than that physicalist strategy. It need not say that phenomenal concepts explain away the hard problem. Even if phenomenal concepts or acquaintance give us a distinctive way of thinking about our own experiences, that fact does not extend first-person warrant to micro-experiences, proto-phenomenal categorical bases, or cosmic subjectivity.

Stoljar's ignorance hypothesis gives a related caution. If part of the pressure toward panpsychism arises from ignorance of the relevant physical or categorical facts, then the proper response is not to deny the datum of consciousness, but to separate the datum from speculative claims about what must underlie it (Stoljar 2006). This is close to the pressure applied here, though the argument does not depend on any physicalist or ignorance-based diagnosis succeeding. The introspective warrant constraint is compatible with the ignorance view but does not require it. Whether or not our ignorance of categorical facts is what generates the pressure toward panpsychism, first-person acquaintance is bounded by what it discloses, and that bound holds even if further categorical facts exist. Before adding hidden phenomenal properties to reality,

we should ask what explanatory work they perform beyond marking our resistance to brute emergence.

A panpsychist may reply that this burden is shared. Mendelovici argues that the combination problem resembles structural problems faced by many theories of consciousness, including problems of phenomenal unity, mental structure, and new quality spaces (Mendelovici 2019). Saad offers a different abductive route, arguing that psychophysical harmony can support panpsychism independently of the first-person route criticized here (Saad 2022). I grant both points. Physicalism also owes an account of why organization gives rise to experience, unless it denies or deflates the explanandum. The claim here is limited. Panpsychism is not alone in facing structural burdens, and independent abductive arguments may be possible. Panpsychist arguments that make no claim on first-person warrant, of which Saad’s harmony argument is the cleanest case, are outside the target. The introspective warrant constraint is a discipline on how first-person evidence is used; it has nothing to say about views that do not use it. First-person evidence cannot by itself pay the cost of the hidden phenomenal base. Where panpsychism is defended by harmony, phenomenal powers, cosmopsychic individuation, or composite subjectivity, its warrant is theoretical and should be evaluated as such.

Dreamless sleep is a useful illustration. Dreamless sleep does not prove that consciousness is absent. A panpsychist, a Buddhist philosopher, or a theorist of minimal consciousness may argue that some form of experience occurs without later memory. Such a claim requires independent warrant. If there is no memory, no report, no phenomenological trace, and no distinctive explanatory payoff, then first-person evidence does not license the posit.

Temporal grain illustrates the same pattern. Human consciousness appears to have thresholds and integration windows. Some stimuli may be processed without entering experience at all, and conscious episodes seem to depend on temporally organized uptake rather than on every event in the nervous system surfacing as experience. A panpsychist can say, consistently, that sub-threshold processes still have micro-experiential aspects. But that reply does not yet explain why ordinary consciousness has the temporal boundaries it has, why some processed information enters experience while other information does not, or why integration at one scale yields a conscious episode while nearby subpersonal processing remains outside awareness. If hidden experientiality is placed beneath the threshold, the question is what it explains about the threshold. Without such an account, the posit multiplies hidden phenomenal facts beneath temporal structure rather than explaining that structure.

These examples illustrate the warrant problem; they are not empirical proofs against panpsychism. Panpsychism repeatedly posits experience or experience-like properties where experience itself gives no clear warrant. That may be permissible as theory. It is not directly licensed by the first-person datum.

Worries about introspection itself strengthen this restriction. Schwitzgebel argues that introspection may be unreliable even in ordinary cases where we might expect it to be secure (Schwitzgebel 2008, 2011). This worry compounds rather than competes with the present argument. If introspection is fallible even within its proper domain, then the case for restricting its reach is overdetermined. It should be extended beyond

ordinary experience to hidden micro-, proto-, or cosmic phenomenal ontology only with special caution.

9 Conclusion: The Limits of Special Warrant

The argument leaves panpsychism standing, but it blocks a certain use of first-person experience for warrant. First-person experience tells us that there is consciousness, and it tells us something about what conscious life is like. That is real evidence, and the paper does not minimize it. It does not tell us that consciousness is fundamental, microphysical, cosmic, or proto-phenomenal.

Consciousness is real. Panpsychism's further phenomenal posits need a different warrant. They are not supported by the same first-person evidence that supports the reality of consciousness. They may still be defended, but as theory, and by explaining enough to justify their cost. The methodological point is simple: knowing consciousness from within does not by itself settle its metaphysical status.

Panpsychism's central promise changes accordingly. The view appeared to dissolve the explanatory gap in advance by placing phenomenality at the fundamental level, so that ordinary consciousness did not have to arise from anything wholly non-phenomenal. Once first-person inheritance is removed and the hidden phenomenal level is admitted as a theoretical posit, that dissolution is no longer secured in advance. The gap reappears between the hidden base and the consciousness we actually undergo. Goff's recent treatment of subjects as strongly emergent while phenomenal properties are weakly emergent makes the reappearance visible within his own framework (Goff 2024). Panpsychism is entitled to try to close the gap. It is not entitled to claim that the first-person datum has already closed it.

The argument yields a constraint rather than a disproof. Panpsychism may appeal to independent metaphysical arguments, anti-emergentist principles, simplicity considerations, psychophysical harmony, or Russellian claims about intrinsic nature. Those arguments may succeed or fail on their merits. What they may not do is borrow the authority of ordinary first-person consciousness and spend it on entities or structures that ordinary first-person consciousness never reveals. Once the first-person route gives way to abduction, the version on offer, whether austere realistic monism, micropsychism, cosmopsychism, panprotopsychism, or phenomenal-powers grounding, must compete with its rivals on the same abductive terms as any other metaphysical hypothesis.

Nothing here vindicates illusionism or deflationary physicalism. Those views face their own burden, since denying or deflating the first-person datum carries a substantial cost. The claim is narrower. Any view that takes first-person consciousness seriously must also respect the limits of what first-person consciousness discloses.

Where panpsychism treats the epistemic privilege of ordinary consciousness as support for a hidden phenomenal ontology, it overdraws on experience. The broader pattern is a temptation to move too quickly from phenomenology to fundamental metaphysics. Panpsychism in its first-person-motivated forms is the central case considered here, but the corrective is more general.

The first-person datum remains indispensable, but the metaphysics built on top of it requires argument of its own.

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